

A Flat in the Old Quarter

She had a month, a small flat, and no obligations.
She had not expected how hard that would be.

CEFR Level A2

Book 8 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: Lisbon, Portugal. A rented flat in the Alfama neighbourhood. January.

Genre: Personal Growth / Travel

Characters

- Cara — 41. Former academic. Left her university post eight months ago. Still figuring out what comes next.
- Senhor Dias — 70. The landlord. Lives downstairs. Knows the neighbourhood thoroughly.
- Fatima — 35. A local woman Cara meets at a language class.
- The city itself — treated throughout as a kind of character.

The flat was on the third floor of a narrow building in Alfama.

The staircase was steep and the walls were tiled in traditional blue and white.

The flat itself was small: a bedroom, a kitchen, a sitting room with a view of the rooftops, and a bathroom with a window that opened onto a ventilation shaft.

Cara stood in the sitting room with her suitcase and looked at the rooftops.

She had rented the flat for one month. She had no specific plans.

This was, she reminded herself, the point.

Eight months ago, Cara had resigned from her position as a lecturer in comparative literature.

It had not been a crisis — no scandal, no breakdown. Just a slow, gathering certainty that she no longer wanted to be there.

She had saved enough to take a year. She had sublet her flat in Cambridge.

She had spent the first three months organising. The next three trying to write.

She had not written much.

Lisbon had been her sister's idea. 'Go somewhere you don't know,' her sister had said. 'Somewhere that doesn't ask anything of you.'

On her second morning, Cara went downstairs to introduce herself properly.

Senhor Dias opened the door in a cardigan and offered her coffee.

His English was careful and slightly formal.

'You are here for one month,' he said. 'Alone.' It was an observation, not a question.

'Yes.' 'You are working?' Cara paused. 'Not exactly. I'm — taking some time.'

Senhor Dias nodded as if this were a perfectly reasonable answer.

'Alfama is a good place for taking time,' he said. 'It does not hurry.'

The first week was harder than she had expected.

She had imagined herself walking, reading, sitting in cafés, thinking clearly.

Instead, she felt a low, persistent anxiety that she could not identify or resolve.

She walked a lot. She read some. She sat in cafés and looked at other people working on laptops and felt a vague, irritating envy.

On Thursday, she called her sister.

'I don't know what I'm supposed to be doing,' she said.

'Nothing,' her sister said. 'That's the point.'

'But I don't know how to do nothing.'

In the second week, Cara signed up for a beginner's Portuguese class at a local cultural centre.

She had studied languages before — French, German — but Portuguese was new.

The class met three mornings a week. There were eight students: three tourists, two long-term residents, a retired Irish couple, and Fatima, who was practising for a work certification.

Fatima had lived in Lisbon all her life. She spoke English fluently but rarely.

'I want to improve,' she told Cara. 'Speaking is not enough. I need to write correctly.'

'I understand that exactly,' Cara said.

Lisbon, Cara decided, was designed to disorient you pleasantly.

A Flat in the Old Quarter



Cara arrives in Lisbon with a suitcase and no clear plan.

The streets of Alfama were narrow and often led somewhere unexpected. You turned a corner and found a courtyard. You followed a staircase and found a viewpoint.

She began walking without a map.

This was harder than it sounded — not physically, but psychologically. She was someone who had always known exactly where she was going.

Getting lost on purpose was an exercise in trusting that she would eventually come out somewhere.

She always did. Though not always where she had planned.

In the third week, Fatima took Cara to a small fado bar in the upper part of Alfama.

Fado was the traditional music of Lisbon — melancholic, precise, built on loss.

Cara had read about it. Reading about it had not prepared her.

The singer was a woman in her fifties. She sang three songs. During the last one, Cara found herself unable to look at anything.

Outside afterwards, Fatima said: 'You look — affected.'
'I am,' Cara said. 'I didn't expect that.'

'Most people don't,' Fatima said. 'That's why we bring them.'

That evening, Cara sat in the flat and tried to understand what had happened.

She thought: I have been trying to figure out what I want to do next. And the music reached something that the thinking hadn't.

She didn't know what it had reached, exactly. Just that something was there that she hadn't acknowledged.

She opened her notebook — the one she hadn't really used — and began to write.

Not an essay. Not notes. Just — what she was feeling, what she was thinking, what she was missing.

She wrote for ninety minutes. When she stopped, she felt very tired and slightly lighter.

The following afternoon, Cara met Senhor Dias in the corridor.

He asked how she was finding the city. She said: 'I'm starting to understand it, I think.'

'Lisbon takes time,' he said. 'It does not explain itself quickly.'

He invited her for coffee. They sat in his kitchen, which smelled of coffee and something baking.

'What did you do before this?' he asked.

She told him. He listened without interrupting.

'Literature,' he said when she finished. 'You taught people to read.' 'Yes.' 'And now you are learning to read the city.' He poured more coffee. 'That seems logical.'

Cara and Fatima met for coffee after class twice a week.

Fatima told her about the neighbourhood — the people she had known all her life, the changes, the ones who had left and come back.

She told her about Alfama in winter: how it was quieter, more itself.

'In summer it's full of tourists,' Fatima said. 'They think they are seeing it. But they are seeing the outside. In winter, you see inside.'

'What's on the inside?' Cara asked.

Fatima thought. 'Old people. Children. People who have nowhere else to go. Normal life.'

'I think that's what I'm looking for,' Cara said.

By the middle of the third week, something had settled.

Cara was not producing anything. She was not making decisions. She was not resolving her future.

But she had stopped feeling the need to, constantly.

She walked. She attended her Portuguese class. She sat with Senhor Dias for coffee.

She wrote in her notebook — not every day, but often.

She ate dinner alone at a small restaurant at the end of the street three times a week. She ordered the same thing each time.

The waitress knew her order after the second visit.

Cara's notebook was filling up.

Not with plans or conclusions — with observations.

Things she noticed. Things Fatima had said.

Descriptions of the viewpoints above Alfama. What fado felt like from inside.

She re-read some pages one evening and thought: this is the most honest writing I've done in years.

She had spent the last decade writing academic papers — careful, argued, footnoted.

This was different. It was for no one. It would probably go nowhere.

But it was hers.

In the final week, Cara walked to every viewpoint in Alfama.

There were seven of them. She went to each one in the early morning, when the light was still low.

On the last morning, she went to the highest one and looked out across the city and the river.

She thought about the past month. About what she had done — and what she had not done.

She had not made a decision about her future. She had not written anything publishable.

A Flat in the Old Quarter



The city begins to speak to Cara through music and friendship.

She had filled a notebook. She had learned twenty-six words in Portuguese.

She had had her first real conversation with a neighbour since Cambridge.

On her last evening, Senhor Dias knocked on the door. He brought a small bottle of wine and two glasses. They sat on the small balcony and looked at the rooftops.

'Will you come back?' he asked.

Cara thought. 'I think so,' she said. 'Not soon. But yes.'

'The flat will be here,' he said. He was quiet for a moment. 'You came looking for something,' he said. 'Did you find it?'

Cara looked at the city. 'I'm not sure,' she said. 'But I think I found where to look.'

Cara's flight was at noon.

She left the flat at nine thirty, to walk one last time through the neighbourhood.

She went to the fado bar — it was closed in the morning, but she stood outside for a moment.

She went to the coffee place where she and Fatima had met.

She went past the viewpoint above the church.

She said goodbye to each place in her head. This was something she had never done before — marked a leaving.

She had always just left.

Back in Cambridge, the flat was cold and slightly dusty. Cara opened the windows and made tea.

She unpacked slowly. She put the notebook on the desk.

She had emailed Fatima from the airport. Fatima had replied: Come back in spring. The tiles are different colours in the rain.

Cara looked at her desk. The academic papers she had been half-writing were still there.

She moved them to a shelf.

She put the notebook in their place.

Over the following weeks, Cara kept writing in the notebook.

She was not sure what she was writing. It was not a memoir — it was too specific and too small for that. It was not an essay.

She showed a few pages to her sister. Her sister read them slowly.

'This is really good,' her sister said. 'What is it?'

'I don't know yet,' Cara said.

'That's fine,' her sister said. 'You can figure out what it is after.'

Cara thought about fado. About how it knew what it was without needing to explain.

In March, Cara made a decision.

She would not go back to academia. She had known this for a while, but she had been reluctant to say it to herself directly.

She sat at her desk and wrote it in the notebook: I am not going back.

Under it, she wrote: That means I have to figure out what I am going forward.

Under that, she wrote: I am a person who can write. I know how to observe. I know how to read a place.

She looked at the three sentences for a long time.

It wasn't a plan. But it was a starting point.

A Flat in the Old Quarter



By the end of the month, uncertainty has become a different kind of clarity.

In May, Fatima came to Cambridge for a work conference.

They met for dinner. Fatima had passed her certification.

'Your English was always fine,' Cara said.

'It is better now,' Fatima said. 'More precise. I can say what I mean more exactly.'

'That's the whole thing, isn't it,' Cara said. 'Being able to say what you mean exactly.'

Fatima smiled. 'Is that what you are working on?'

Cara thought about the notebook. About the three sentences. About fado.

'Yes,' she said. 'I think it is.'

In June, Cara booked the flat in Alfama again.

Two weeks this time. She had something to write — or the beginning of something.

Senhor Dias replied to her email with one line: The flat is free. The tiles are still blue.

She wrote back: I'll bring better Portuguese.

He replied: Bring the notebook.

She laughed at her desk in Cambridge.

She closed the laptop. She opened the notebook to a blank page.

She wrote the date at the top.

She began.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. staircase	merdiven
2. tiled	karo kaplı
3. rooftops	çatılar
4. ventilation shaft	havalandırma boşluğu
5. no specific plans	belirli planlar yok
6. reminded herself	kendine hatırlattı
7. resigned	istifa etti
8. lecturer	öğretim görevlisi
9. comparative literature	karşılaştırmalı edebiyat
10. sublet	alt kirasını verdi
11. gathering certainty	yavaş yavaş büyüyen kesinlik
12. breakdown	çöküş
13. introduce herself	kendini tanıtmak
14. observation	gözlem
15. cardigan	hırka
16. hurry	acele etmek
17. carefully and formal	dikkatli ve resmi
18. perfectly reasonable	son derece makul
19. persistent	kalıcı, süregelen
20. anxiety	kaygı
21. resolve	çözmek
22. vague	belirsiz
23. irritating envy	sinir bozucu kıskançlık
24. identify	tanımlamak
25. beginner's class	başlangıç sınıfı
26. cultural centre	kültür merkezi
27. fluently	akıcı şekilde
28. certification	sertifika
29. long-term residents	uzun süreli sakinler
30. rarely	nadiren
31. disorient	şaşırtmak
32. courtyard	avlu
33. viewpoint	bakış noktası
34. psychologically	psikolojik olarak
35. eventually	eninde sonunda
36. on purpose	bilerek
37. fado	fado (Portekiz müziği)
38. melancholic	melankolik

39. built on loss	kayıp üzerine inşa edilmiş
40. affected	etkilenmiş
41. precise	kesin, hassas
42. unable to look	bakamaz
43. figure out	anlamak
44. reached	ulaştı
45. acknowledged	kabul etti
46. essay	deneme, makale
47. slightly lighter	hafifçe rahatlamış
48. notebook	defter
49. explains itself	kendini açıklar
50. interrupted	sözünü kesti
51. logical	mantıklı
52. baking	pişirme
53. teaching people to read	insanlara okumayı öğretmek
54. neighbourhood	mahalle
55. normal life	normal hayat
56. quieter, more itself	daha sessiz, daha kendisi
57. nowhere else to go	başka gidecek yer yok
58. outside vs inside	dışarı ve içerisi
59. settled	yerleşti, sakinleşti
60. producing	üretmek
61. constantly	sürekli
62. attended	devam etti
63. resolving	çözüme kavuşturmak
64. same thing each time	her seferinde aynı şeyi
65. conclusions	sonuçlar
66. observations	gözlemler
67. honest writing	dürüst yazı
68. footnoted	dipnotlanmış
69. argued	tartışmalı
70. decade	on yıl
71. viewpoint	manzara noktası
72. publishable	yayımlanabilir
73. low light	alçak ışık
74. filled a notebook	defteri doldurdu
75. real conversation	gerçek sohbet
76. across the city	şehrin karşısında

77. farewell	veda
78. balcony	balkon
79. looking for something	bir şey arıyor
80. where to look	nereye bakacağını
81. not soon	yakın zamanda değil
82. small bottle	küçük şişe
83. said goodbye in her head	içinden veda etti
84. marked a leaving	bir ayrılığı işaretlemek
85. noon	öğle
86. stood outside	dışarıda durdu
87. last time	son kez
88. dusty	tozlu
89. unpacked	bavulunu açtı
90. half-writing	yarım bırakılmış
91. tiles	karolar, çiniler
92. emailed	e-posta gönderdi
93. in their place	onların yerine
94. memoir	anı
95. specific	özgün, belirli
96. figure out after	sonra anlamak
97. knew what it was	ne olduğunu biliyordu
98. explain	açıklamak
99. a few pages	birkaç sayfa
100. academia	akademi
101. reluctant	isteksiz
102. directly	doğrudan
103. starting point	başlangıç noktası
104. going forward	ileriye doğru gitmek
105. observe	gözlemlemek
106. certification	sertifika
107. precise	kesin
108. more exactly	daha tam olarak
109. working on	üzerinde çalışmak
110. conference	konferans
111. whole thing	tüm mesele
112. booked	rezervasyon yaptı
113. blank page	boş sayfa
114. replied	yanıtladı

- 115. beginning of something
- 116. closed the laptop
- 117. began

bir şeyin başlangıcı
dizüstü bilgisayarı kapattı
başladı

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. lecturer
- A. istifa
2. resignation
- B. öğretim görevlisi
3. melancholic
- C. çözme
4. resolve
- D. melankolik
5. sublet
- E. alt kira
6. persistent
- F. kalıcı
7. viewpoint
- G. manzara noktası
8. publishable
- H. yayımlanabilir

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

nothing — notebook — fado — settled — starting — city

1. Her sister told her to go somewhere that doesn't ask _____ of her.
2. Cara said 'I don't know how to do _____.'
3. After the second week, something _____ in Cara — she stopped needing to resolve everything.
4. _____ reached something in Cara that thinking had not.
5. Her most honest writing went into a _____, not into a paper.

6. By the end, she had a _____ point — not a plan, but a direction.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Cara is in Lisbon for a holiday from her university job. ____
2. She chose Lisbon herself, without anyone's suggestion. ____
3. Senhor Dias is unsympathetic to her situation. ____
4. Fatima is a tourist who is visiting Lisbon. ____
5. The fado bar affects Cara deeply. ____
6. Cara decides to return to academia after the trip. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why did Cara leave her university job?
8. What does Senhor Dias mean when he says Alfama "does not hurry"?
9. What problem does Cara face in her first week?
10. What does Fatima tell Cara about the difference between summer and winter in Alfama?
11. What does Cara write in her notebook, and why does it feel different?
12. What does Senhor Dias say when Cara tells him she is a literature teacher?
13. What does Cara do on her last morning in Lisbon?
14. What is the decision Cara makes in March?
15. What does Cara do at the end of the story?

Answer Key

(Alıştırılmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. nothing 2. nothing 3. settled 4. fado 5. notebook 6. starting

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. F

7. A slow, gathering certainty that she no longer wanted to be there — not a crisis, just knowing.

8. It moves at its own pace — it does not demand urgency or productivity from you.

9. She cannot do nothing. She feels a low, persistent anxiety and doesn't know how to just be.

10. In summer tourists see the outside. In winter you see the inside — old people, children, normal life.

11. Observations, feelings, descriptions — not essays or notes. It is the most honest writing she has done in years.

12. He says she taught people to read, and now she is learning to read the city — that seems logical.

13. She walks to each place she has come to love and says goodbye in her head — something she has never done before.

14. She will not go back to academia. She knows this clearly and writes it down.

15. She books the Lisbon flat again, opens her notebook to a blank page, and begins writing.